
The Tsomgo Lake on the way to Nathu La

BEYOND GANGTOK

BEST OF SIKKIM

Gangtok is great. But to get a sense of the 'real' Sikkim, take a road trip across this tiny state that is big on experience

By Priya Pathiyan

Once a royal kingdom, Sikkim has been one of India's northeastern states for 50 years. Even so, not too many travellers have unlocked its great potential. Rich in natural beauty and indigenous culture, it's one of the few unspoilt destinations where you can count on engaging with the local and the authentic. Mountains, glaciers, glacier-fed rivers and lakes, hot springs... it has a wealth of wonders for those who love nature. The Khangchendzonga (or Kanchenjunga) is the country's tallest mountain peak at 8,586 metres, though off-limits to climbers from its Indian side. As a biodiversity hotspot, Sikkim boasts over 4,500 types of flowering plants, including 550 orchid species and 36 rhododendrons, 16 types of conifers, 11 different oaks, 28 kinds of bamboo, 362 varieties of ferns, over 424 medicinal plants, almost 150 different mammals, 550 kinds of birds, 48 types of fish, and over 600 butterfly species! And with over 60 Tibetan monasteries that thrive across the state, it's an important centre for Mahayana Buddhism within India too.

While its capital Gangtok is charming and most developed (in terms of monasteries, flower parks, restaurants, shopping centres and movie theatres), it gives off standard commercial hill-station vibes. The further you explore beyond the capital city, the deeper you'll delve into its true soul. Here are some of our recommendations for your next Sikkim adventure...

Rumtek

The largest monastery in the state, its golden stupa is said to contain the relics of the highly revered 16th Karmapa Lama. The Karma Shri Nalanda Institute for Higher Buddhist Studies is located within the same complex, which is around 24 km from Gangtok. Even as a casual visitor, you sense a certain deep spirituality and contentedness in the aura of this Dharmachakra Centre, accentuated by the timelessness of the surrounding mountains and streams.


The Rumtek monastery